



City of Portland

Office of the
City Administrator
1221 SW 4th Ave.
Portland, OR 97204

EXHIBIT E

Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts Ex-Officio Table

Memo: **Recommendations on the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts from the Ex-Officio Table**

Date: June 26, 2026

From: *Signing Ex-Officio Table Members**
Julia Brim Edwards, Multnomah County Commissioner
Ann Cudd, Portland State University President
Jamie Dunphy, Portland City Councilor
Rich Jaffe, Broadway Across America CEO
Christine Lewis, Metro Councilor
Dana Rokosny, Musicians Union AFM Local 99 President
Sarah Schwarz, PSU Foundation President
Paul Snyder, Oregon Symphony Executive Director
Rose Etta Venetucci, IATSE Local 28
Jessica Vega Pederson, Multnomah County Chair

To: Mayor Keith Wilson

CC: City Administrator Raymond C. Lee III
Deputy City Administrator Donnie Oliveira

Background

On October 10, 2024, Portland City Council unanimously adopted Resolution #37680 to accept the recommendations to pursue a strategy to develop two Broadway-capable venues, avoiding a prolonged closure of the Keller Auditorium, while greenlighting the path ahead for a traffic study, market feasibility study and subsequent financing strategy. Additionally, the resolution authorized the DCA to designate a steering committee to participate in the process – which is running in parallel to the ex-officio table's work.

In November 2025, Mayor Keith Wilson invited key stakeholders from Portland's performing arts ecosystem to join his ex-officio table. The ex-officio table met four times between January-June 2026 to review the details of the City's studies related to this project. The group was tasked with providing guidance on a decision as the City of Portland considers the future of the Keller Auditorium and the potential of a new venue at Portland State University (PSU).

This memo represents a visionary future of performing-arts venues, drawing on the results of a survey completed in late May 2026 to solicit the opinions of individual table members.

A Phased, Two-Venue Solution to Reignite Portland's Performing Arts Ecosystem

While ex-officio members had a range of support across both venue options, nearly all members understand that closing the Keller Auditorium without an alternative venue is not a viable option and would carry major risks to Portland's downtown economy and business, workers and culture. Given that nearly universal conclusion from the ex-officio table, this recommendation offers a vision that would sequence both projects – first building a new, Broadway-capable venue at PSU, keeping Keller Auditorium operational during construction and continue serving as Portland's Broadway theatre and allowing the City to move next steps forward in renovating Keller Auditorium into a 1200–1800 seat facility that addresses unmet market needs.

This strategic, phased plan allows the City to leverage state funding already provided to the PSU site, protect downtown economic activity every step of the way, and usher in a future of downtown performing arts that is right-sized to meet the facility capacity needs across the performing arts ecosystem.

With this vision, we can position Portland as a performing arts capital for generations to come, with a range of venues that support the arts community across Portland and beyond.

Approach

A two-year closure of the Keller without a suitable alternative venue would create significant economic losses for downtown, threaten hundreds of jobs, and weaken the city's recovery. Maintaining Broadway programming is essential to sustaining Portland's arts economy and its surrounding ecosystem of hospitality, tourism, and retail.

Among the group, most viewed a large-scale, Broadway-capable venue at PSU as the most forward-looking investment. It creates a purpose-built facility aligned with the needs of modern production and unlocks access to diverse funding pathways, including state investment.

It is essential to keep Keller Auditorium operational during the multi-year PSU design and construction period. This ensures that Portland retains major touring productions, protects the workforce that supports these productions, and maintains a critical revenue stream for the other venues of Portland's Centers for the Arts. This strategic approach to maintaining ongoing Broadway in downtown safeguards the region during a period of long-term economic recovery following the COVID-19 pandemic.

During PSU's construction period, the City would plan next steps to reenvision the Keller as a right-sized, modernized, City-owned asset. With a 1200–1800 seat capacity, the Keller can serve a significant unmet need for mid-sized performance space – demand repeated in the market feasibility study commissioned to support this work. By right-sizing to a smaller venue, a Keller renovation could include larger lobby and rehearsal spaces, expanded artist amenities, and opportunities to allow for more community utilization of the space, providing options that the current performing arts landscape cannot accommodate.

Once both phases are complete, with a new PSU venue combined with a modernized, mid-sized Keller, Portland will have a more sustainable and multi-tiered performing arts ecosystem. This future-looking strategy will set Portland up to attract more performing arts productions; continue to build on its downtown arts district; and leads to decades of investment in downtown – while still addressing more immediate operational needs.

Recommendations

The ex-officio table recommends that the City should pursue the following direction:

- First, advance the PSU performing arts center, capitalizing on available state funding, partner momentum and a future forward vision that expands Portland's arts ecosystem.
- As next steps in planning, the Technical Advisory Committee (TAC) will complete the following actions along with other pre-development functions:
 - A clear understanding of the City's obligations and costs for the PSU project
 - Analysis on the return on invested capital (ROIC)
 - A fully defined capital stack
 - Funding timelines.
- While PSU development is ongoing, maintain Broadway shows at the Keller to avoid economic disruption and preserve programming continuity.
- At the same time, initiate planning for the Keller's future – including financial analysis, market feasibility, and design – to allow for construction to begin once the PSU venue opens.
- When the PSU venue becomes operational, transition Broadway productions there, and begin renovation of the Keller into a modern 1200–1800 seat venue tailored to the city's mid-size market needs.

** The following Ex Officio Table members did not sign on to the group recommendation:*

Abstained:

Shane Jewell, Oregon Ballet Executive Director

Did not support:

Olivia Clark, Portland City Councilor

Bob Naito, Halprin Landscape Conservancy

LaJune Thorson, Downtown Neighborhood Association Board President

Karen Whitman, Halprin Landscape Conservancy